HOW SQUALIFY WORKS

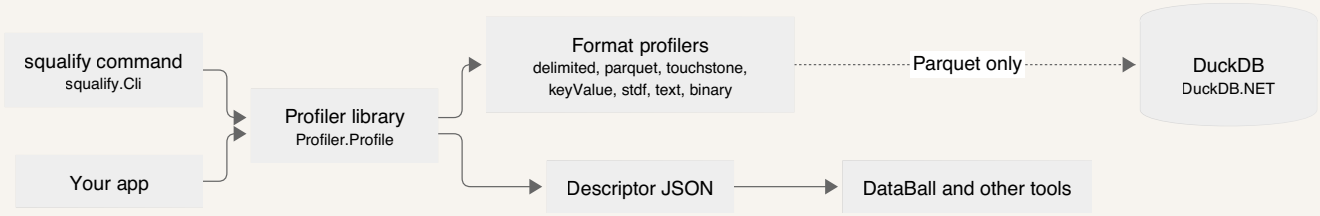
> **Design stage.** This page describes the agreed design (spec pass, 2026-10-13, amended after the sample-data review the same day). No slice has landed yet, so every source file is marked *(planned)*. When an architectural review or a slice changes how squalify works, this page and its diagrams are updated in the same change (see “Docs” in `AGENTS.md`).

squalify reads one data file and writes a **descriptor**: a JSON summary of what the file is and what is inside it. Other tools, such as DataBall, read the descriptor to decide how to handle the file. squalify never changes the file and never needs the network.

Each diagram shows one idea. Labels are in plain language, with the code name in small text. Source paths are relative to `src/squalify/`.

1. THE PIECES

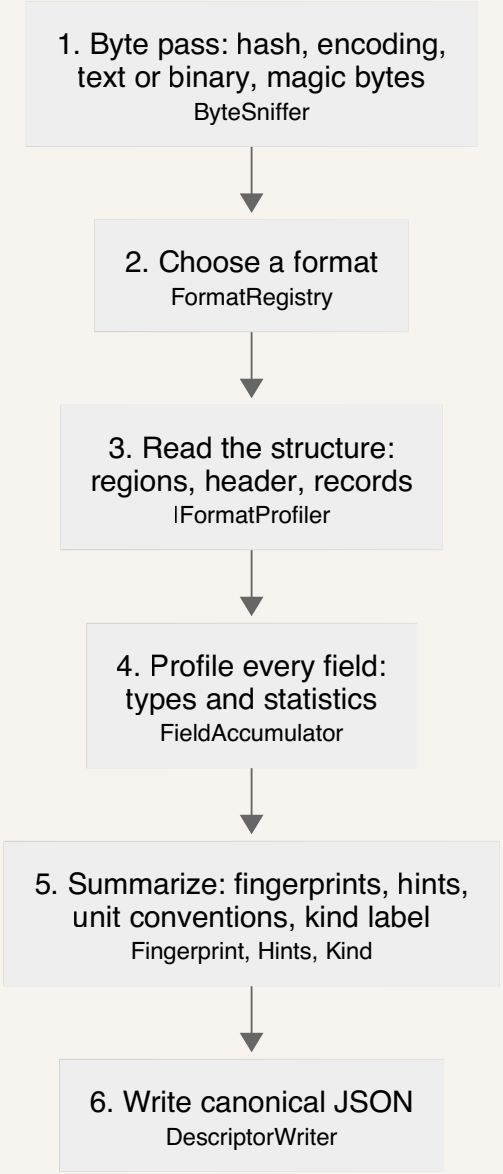
The `squalify` command is a thin shell around the library. Each kind of file has its own profiler. DuckDB is used only to read Parquet. The descriptor is the only thing that leaves the tool.



Source: `Profiler.cs`, `Formats/` (planned).

2. ONE PROFILE RUN

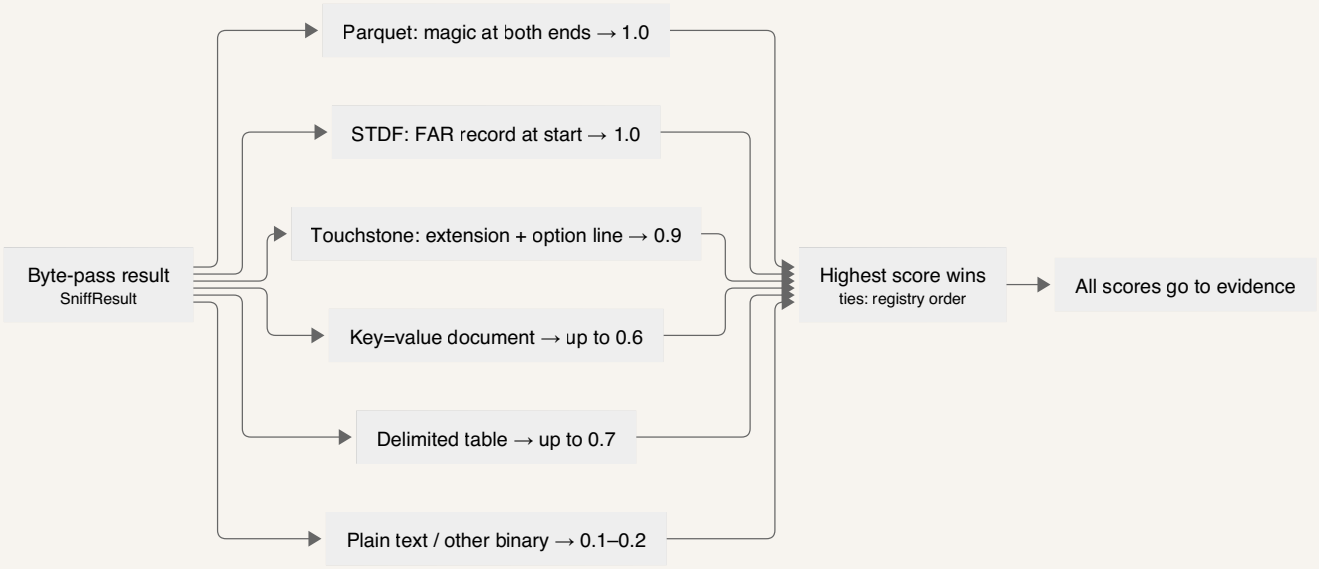
Every file goes through the same steps. A step that reads the file reads all of it, start to end, and keeps only bounded summaries in memory. The file can be far larger than RAM.



Source: `Profiler.cs`, `Sniff/`, `Json/DescriptorWriter.cs` *(planned).*

3. CHOOSING A FORMAT

Every profiler looks at the byte-pass result and gives a score from 0 to 1. The highest score wins, and a tie goes to whichever profiler comes first in the registry list. Every score and its reason are kept in the descriptor's evidence, so you can see why a format was chosen.



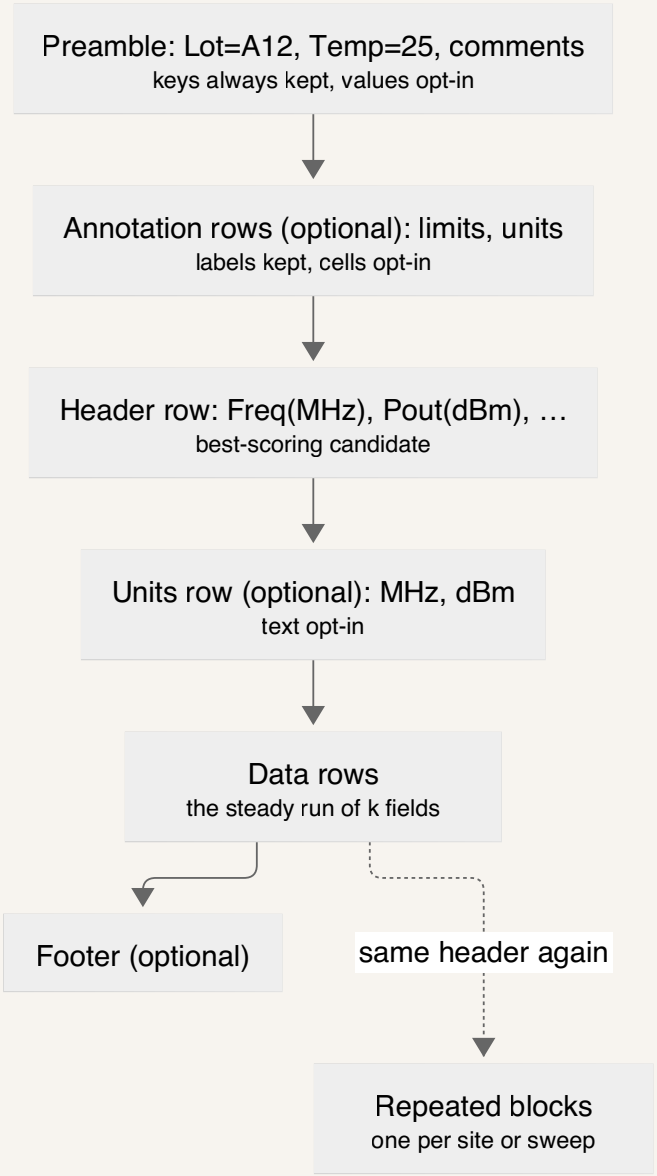
Source: `Formats/FormatRegistry.cs` *(planned).*

4. READING A DELIMITED FILE

A lab CSV is often more than a header and rows. squalify splits the file into regions. It tries every common delimiter at the same time and picks the one that gives the longest steady run of rows with the same field count, and whose cells split cleanly. On tables padded with spaces, splitting on spaces looks almost as steady, so cleanliness decides.

The header is not always the first row of that run. Some exports put rows of limits, units or line numbers above the header, lined up with its columns. squalify scores the first rows of the run and picks the one that

looks most like names over typed data. The rows above it become **annotation** rows: their labels are kept, their cells are opt-in.



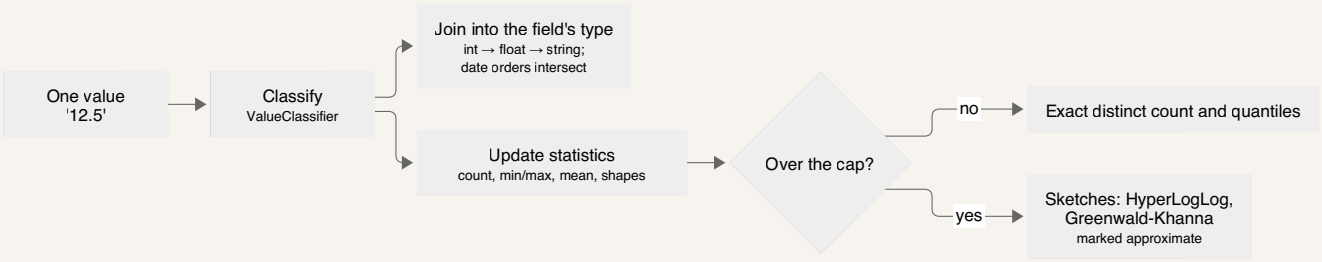
Source: `Delimited/DialectSelector.cs`, `Delimited/HeaderDetector.cs`, `Delimited/BlockDetector.cs` *(planned).*

squalify also reports how the table is padded (fixed line length or not) and whether numbers use a decimal comma. It describes a fixed-width table but still reads every row through the tokenizer.

5. PROFILING ONE FIELD

Each value is classified on its own: empty, true/false, whole number, decimal number, date, time or text. A field's type is the narrowest type that fits **every** non-empty value. Empty markers such as `NA` or `NA.` come from a fixed, versioned list. Statistics are exact up to a cap. Past the cap they switch to a fixed approximation that gives the same answer every time, and the descriptor marks them as approximate.

Dates never assume a locale. `6/5/2026` could be June 5 or May 6, so squalify reports both possible orders and marks the field ambiguous. It then leaves out the date range and whether the dates rise or fall, because both would assume one order.



Source: `Values/ValueClassifier.cs`, `Fields/FieldAccumulator.cs`, `Sketches/` *(planned).*

6. WHAT IS ALWAYS INCLUDED, AND WHAT NEEDS `--include-values`

By default a descriptor describes the **shape** of the data and its statistics, not its contents. Literal text from the file appears only when you ask for it: all of it with `--include-values`, or only named keys and columns with `--include-values-for <name>`.

A column with one value for the whole file, such as a serial number, is a special case. Its range would just be that value, so its statistics are opt-in too.

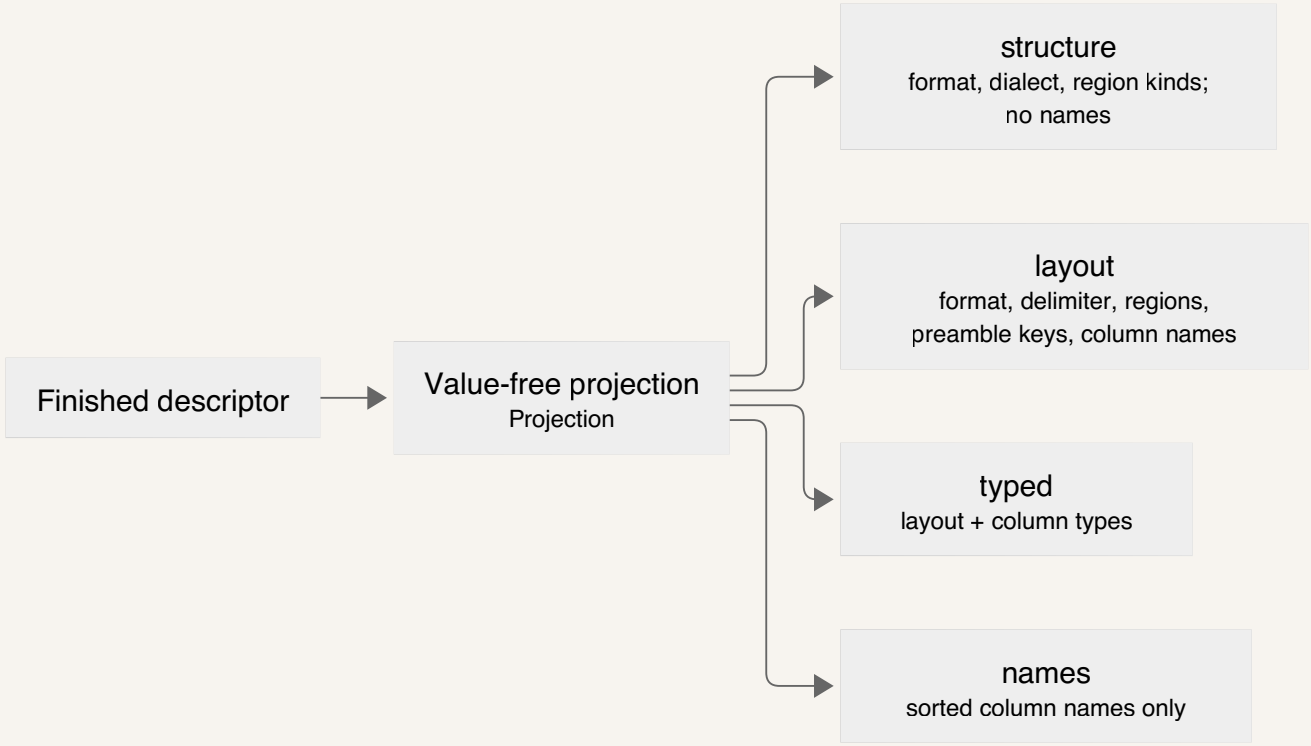
Always included	Only with --include-values
Header names, preamble keys, STDF test names	Preamble and key=value values
Types, counts, shapes	Most common values, text min/max
Number and date ranges, means, quantiles not for one-value columns	Units-row and annotation cells, comment text
Units parsed from header names	Statistics of one-value columns

Source: `ValuesPolicy.cs` *(planned).*

7. FINGERPRINTS

squalify hashes a stripped-down copy of the descriptor that contains no data values. Two files of the same type therefore get the same fingerprint, even when their data differs. There are four fingerprints at different levels of strictness. `structure` uses no column names at all, so it survives a changed column set.

A matching fingerprint does not prove two files are the same kind of file. Many unrelated CSVs share one `structure`, and files whose columns change per run get a new `layout` each time. Consumers combine fingerprints with names and hints.

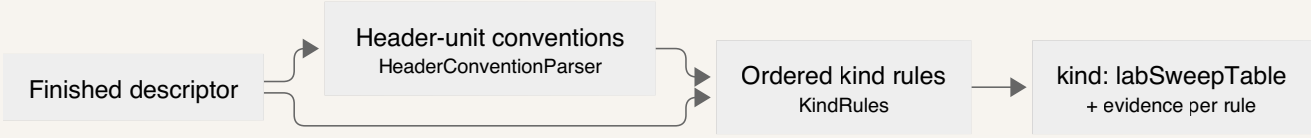


Source: `Fingerprint/Projection.cs` *(planned).*

8. KIND LABEL AND UNIT CONVENTIONS

After profiling, two small rule sets read the finished descriptor. They never read the file.

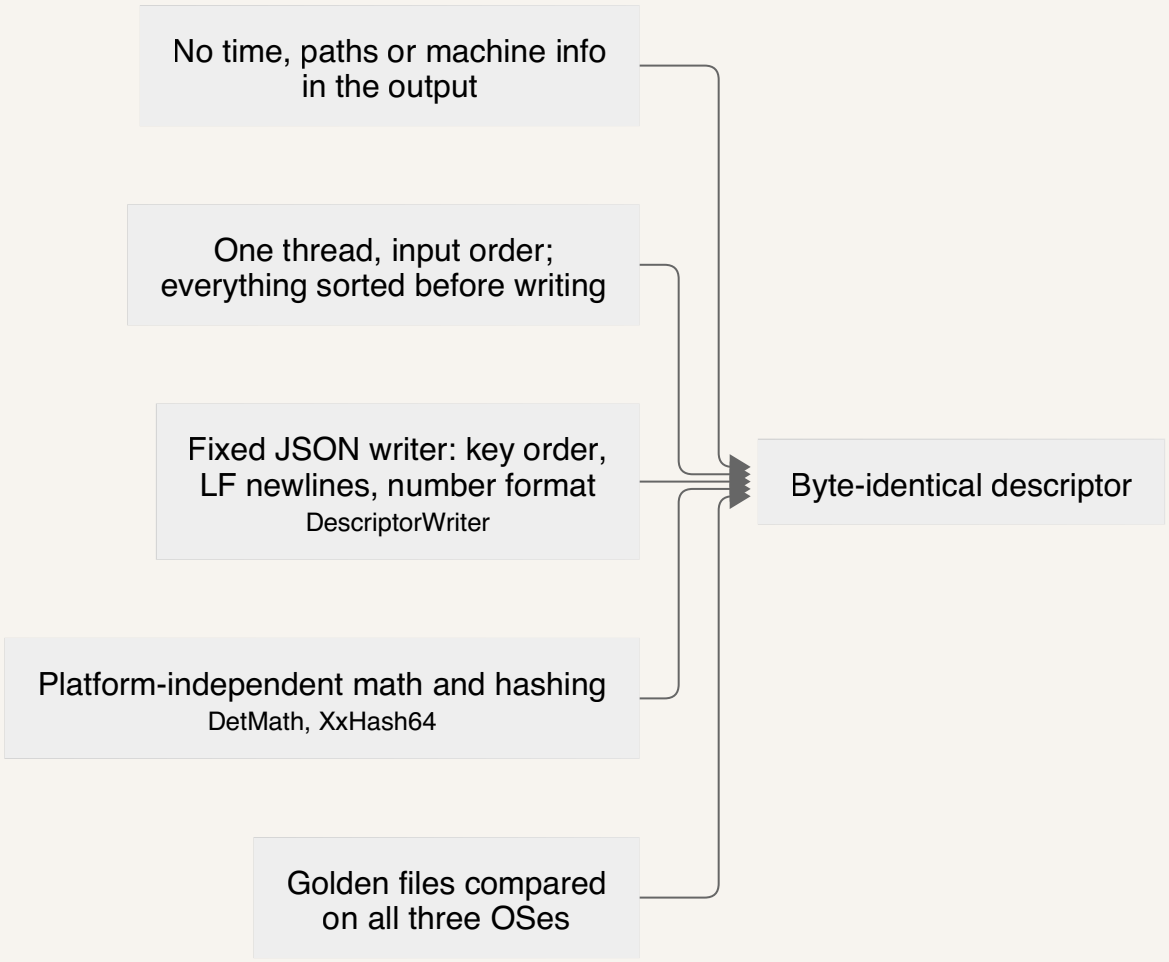
- **Header-unit conventions.** Every column name is checked for how it carries a unit: `I_Total(A)`, `Pout[dBm]`, `VCC_V`, a units row, or none. The most common convention is reported.
- **Kind label.** A fixed, ordered list of rules suggests a generic label, such as `labSweepTable`, `stdfTestLog` or `touchstoneNetwork`. The first rule that matches wins, and every rule's result is kept as evidence.



Source: `Units/`, `Kind/` *(planned).*

9. WHY THE OUTPUT NEVER CHANGES

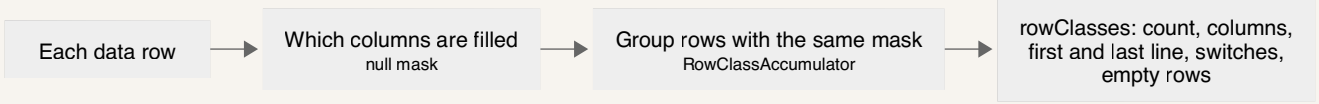
The same file and the same squalify version always give the same descriptor, byte for byte, on Windows, macOS and Linux. Five guardrails make that true.



Source: `Determinism/`, `Json/` *(planned);* `tests/squalify.Tests/Golden.cs` *(planned).*

10. ROW CLASSES

Some exports mix several kinds of row in one table: measurement rows, setup rows, error rows and empty separator rows, switching kind on almost every line. squalify groups rows by which columns are filled in and reports each group, how often the kind switches, and how many rows are empty. Column null counts are also given without the empty rows, so separators do not look like missing measurements.



Source: `Fields/RowClassAccumulator.cs` *(planned).*